

PERSONAL NOTES ON PROGRAM DESIGN · UPLIFT MENTORSHIP PROGRAM

We're Building a Diner

How we proudly Jersified program design in the best way possible: by following diners.

My personal notes on how I approach program design: my reflections on how I was able to influence the way this version of Uplift got designed, the factors behind it, and the easy analogies I keep reaching for.

KENNEDY LOPER · TECHUNITED:NJ · SEPTEMBER 2026

A NOTE BEFORE WE START

These are my notes.

So what is this, and why am I talking about a diner? This is a walkthrough of how I think about the educational side of Uplift, TechUnited's eight-week mentorship program for New Jersey founders. The diner is the closest thing I know to a place that feeds everyone a little differently, on their schedule, and still feels like home. It turned out to be the easiest way to explain the choices we made.

I've enjoyed adding personal notes to this, because there is no right or wrong way to build a program. This one has been immensely influenced by the support, knowledge, small hacks, insider info, mentors, and peers I wish I'd had, and still want to have. Nothing here is a decision in print for Uplift. It's my personal take on everything TechUnited has been able to provide me, and provide the program.

I've also been told I think pretty creatively and abstractly about the way I structure things. Putting the way I communicate into a version like this helps me make the most compelling argument I can. Though let's be real, I'm not always the most concise.

I've also immensely enjoyed the leverage AI has given me. As an outlet for creativity. As a way to make ten of me. As a way to communicate better, express my thoughts better, and share all of these stories with you. Typically we're all so busy working that we never get to share how much fun it was to build, and I believe work should be fun every day. Some days it should be hard. Some days it won't be enjoyable. But the headline should be fun. That's what this is.

Another fun fact: I typically spend 8:15 to 8:45 every morning writing LinkedIn content about the work I get to contribute to at TechUnited. It helps me tell my story, tell the community's story, and frankly build leverage with partners who want to be part of the ecosystem. That's about how long this post took, and not just the graphic itself. From notes on my iPhone, from the moment the analogy popped into my head, to the time I set aside this morning to map it out and share it with you: pulling together everything about how I've built the program, settling on the diner, voice-typing my thoughts through Superwhisper, and leaning on my Granola notes to get it onto paper. And then, of course, I queue it, because I get terrible anxiety the second I press the post button. Who knows why. Thanks to the resources, tools, and documentation I've been able to leverage now that AI has changed what's possible in the work.

Kennedy Loper

THE PARAMETERS

Here's what we were designing around.

The givens, before any metaphors.

GUEST CHECK		NO. 0070
TABLE ~70 founders	SERVER Kennedy	DATE Fall 2026
TIME	Eight weeks.	
FOUNDERS	~70, at wildly different stages: validating, MVP, generating revenue, hiring, looking for customers or partnerships.	
EDUCATION	Three 30-minute sessions a week. Different days, different topics, different voices. 22 opportunities over the program.	
MENTORSHIP	Discover → Act → Roadmap (<i>this is how we recommend you structure the time you spend with your mentor</i>). Where are you actually? What can you do next? What have we learned about where you go from there?	
REALITY	Founders with full-time jobs, families, mortgages, dogs, and about 47 other things competing for the same Tuesday night.	
PHASE 2	TechUnited's monthly firesides and broader programming, for the bigger conversations.	
BACKDROP	NJEDA's FY26 “pilot, learn, scale” culture and its mission to increase equitable access to opportunity.	
THE JOB		Access
<i>Substitutions encouraged, beyond what's required.</i> <i>Everything after this page is how these went from a concept, to a diner, to tangible community change.</i>		



DINER

START HERE

For this stage of Uplift, we're solving for access.

Before you design a program, you probably need to agree on what you're actually asking the program to solve for.

Access to mentors. Access to education. Access to people and tools that might help you figure out your next move.

We have eight weeks. We're serving ~70 founders at wildly different stages.

Their A's are different. Which means their A.1's are different.

So I'm not interested in pretending I can prescribe one curriculum that gets all 70 of them to B.

If I were to Jerseify it: we're building a diner.

SAME COUNTER, DIFFERENT ORDERS

A isn't the same place for everyone.

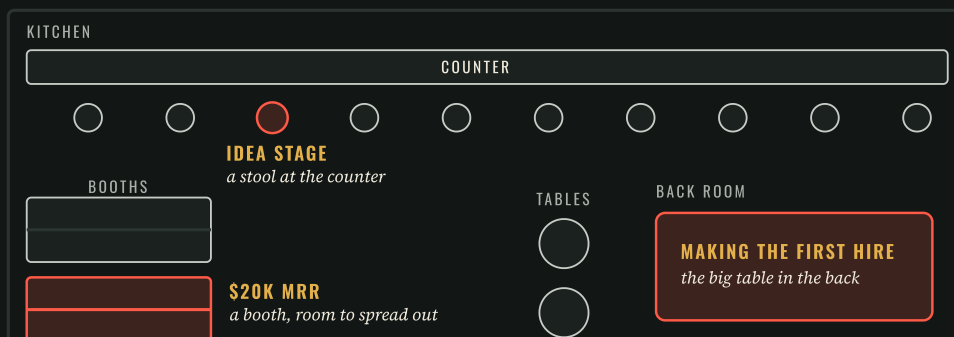
Imagine running an eight-week summer camp for K-12 and giving every student the same four 90-minute classes. The classes could be phenomenal. You'd still miss the mark, because they're not all starting from the same place.

That's essentially the challenge we're designing around with Uplift. Some of our founders are validating. Some have an MVP. Some are generating revenue. Some are hiring. Some are looking for customers or partnerships.

One founder's A might be an idea.

Another founder's A might be \$20K MRR.

Another founder's A might be figuring out how to make their first hire.



They all walk into the same diner. They just need a different setup. Their A's are different, so their A.1's are going to be different too. The difference between them is stage, not sophistication or capability.

I'm not deciding where B should be for any of them. I'm trying to put enough useful tools and people within reach that each founder has a better shot at finding their own A.1.



NOTHING WRONG WITH WINGS

Think of your educational sessions as a menu, not a curriculum.

Context: in the program, alongside a one-on-one mentor, this diner (Uplift) also provides educational sessions intended to support and serve the founders in it. Remember, these are people coming from different stages, for different reasons, with different appetites, different availability, and different schedules. Those sessions are the menu. If I know you need to be somewhere at six, I'm not telling you to order the soufflé.

We're the diner, not the place that only serves wings. There is absolutely nothing wrong with wings. But if I'm feeding 70 people, I'm not going to decide ahead of time that wings are what everyone needs.

So we built a menu. Not everything on the menu is for you. That's why there's a menu.

And I have to eat all these wings? Are you sure I have to eat the wings?

FOUR BETS, OR TWENTY-TWO OPPORTUNITIES

We could make four big bets. Or create 22 chances.

We could program four 90-minute workshops and make four pretty big bets about what all of them need to know. Or we can create 22 different opportunities for a founder to encounter a tool, framework, person, warning, or idea that helps them move forward.

WINGS ONLY

4

4 workshops × 90 minutes
4 topics we decide are important
4 pretty big bets

Hope you like wings.

vs

THE MENU

22

3 sessions a week × 30 minutes
3 days, 3 topics, 3 voices
22 opportunities to encounter something useful

Order what you actually need.

EIGHT WEEKS, TWO WAYS TO SPEND THEM

We chose the latter. Three 30-minute educational sessions a week. Three different days. Three different topics. Three different voices.

NOTICE

PLEASE INFORM YOUR SERVER OF ANY ALLERGIES OR FOOD RESTRICTIONS

Where are you actually? What do you need next? What should we skip?

Your application and everything I asked for during onboarding? That was the server asking about any allergies or food restrictions we should know about. It's also what told us why this menu made more sense for you than standing up a Wingstop.

TRANSLATION

The wings are one fixed curriculum. The menu is 22 short sessions on different topics. We chose the menu because 70 founders at 70 different points can't all need the same four things.

22 OPPORTUNITIES

Take what you need. Skip what you don't. Come back next week.

Not every founder should attend every session. That's the point.

There is an obvious counterargument here: try to please everyone and you end up pleasing no one.

I agree.

Which is why I'm not trying to make every session relevant to every founder. The menu can be broad because each item can be specific.

If eight founders desperately need a session and 62 don't, that session might be doing its job perfectly.

Was this the best coffee ever? I don't know. Was the experience epic? Heck yeah.

THE KITCHEN IS TAKING REQUESTS

Have a session idea? I'd love to hear it. Things like:

- How you automate your email responses
- How you run a design thinking workshop
- How to curate your elevator pitch
- How to take your deck from v1 to professionally designed
- How to grow your network intentionally
- How to be less transactional when you still have a goal

BACK TO THE MENU: THE SPECIALS BOARD

"I already had the problem. I just didn't know there was a tool for it."

When I think about the frameworks and tools I use all the time now, most of them weren't things I knew to go looking for. A SWOT analysis. A 30/60/90. Flywheels. Design thinking. Building personas to understand your ICP.

At some point, someone put one in front of me and said: "Use this." And sometimes the most valuable knowledge someone with more experience can give you is the opposite.

Today's specials	OFF THE UPLIFT MENU · 3 A WEEK · 30 MINUTES
<i>Server recommends: "Use this."</i> A SWOT analysis A 30/60/90 Flywheels Design thinking Personas, to understand your ICP	<i>Server says: "Skip that."</i> Don't use this. Skip that. You don't need to worry about that yet. The 14-step MCP adapter stack that gets you to a billion dollars? Not what you came here for.
Take what you need. Skip what you don't. Come back next week.	

There is more business knowledge available today than any founder could possibly consume. The challenge isn't finding more information. It's encountering the right piece of information, from the right person, close enough to the moment you can actually use it.

I'm not here to prescribe your solution. I'm here to put enough potential tools within reach that you have a better chance of finding it.

How would I know to order this special if you didn't tell me what you'd recommend? It might be our lemon meringue cream pie special of the day, or that tiny tidbit of a framework that changes your trajectory. Ultimately, you choose.

**THE DINER BURGER**

Who has time for a three-course meal every Monday?

And I think how we deliver those tools matters too. Eight weeks isn't enough time to teach someone everything they need to know about building a company, and I'm not interested in pretending it is. I also don't think education automatically becomes more valuable because we keep someone in a room longer.

And the reality is, the founders we serve have lives. A full-time job. A startup. Kids. A mortgage. A relationship. A dog that needs to go out. Dinner that needs to get made. And about 47 other things competing for the same Tuesday night.

And we've all had the other experience too. You go to the fancy restaurant. It's beautiful. The chef is brilliant. Every course has a paragraph explaining it. Two hours later you walk out thinking:

“That was great. I have no idea what I just ate. And I'm still kind of hungry.”

Sometimes you need the diner burger. Thirty minutes. Good. Filling. You know exactly what you got. Now get back to your day.

TRANSLATION

The three-course meal is a 90-minute workshop. The diner burger is a 30-minute session on one topic, built so you can use it tomorrow.

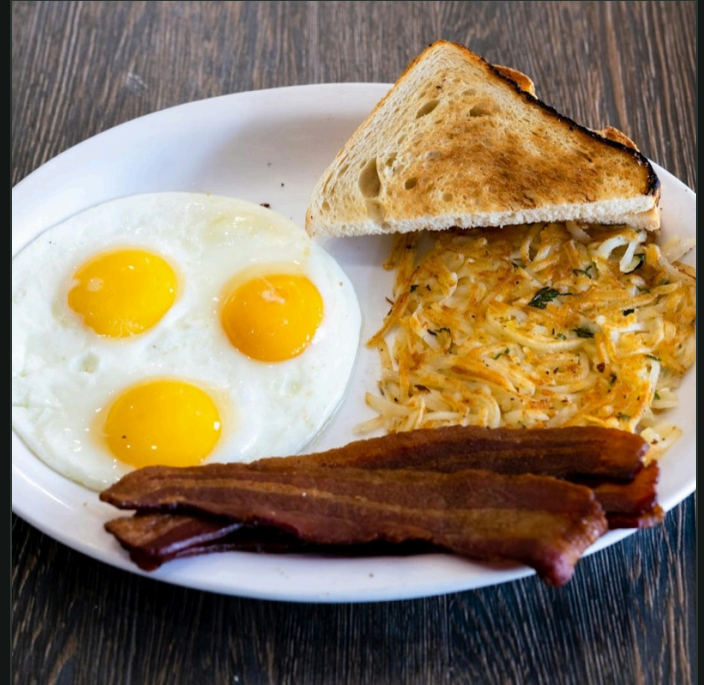
THAT'S WHAT I WANT FROM THESE SESSIONS

Not education designed to impress you while you're consuming it. Education you can actually use after you leave.



BELLS AND WHISTLES

All the ambiance is meant to entice you. Ultimately, you get a Yelp review.



THE PLACE YOU COME BACK TO EVERY WEEK

Even on your birthday. You know exactly what you're getting, and it's exactly what you needed.

Give me the framework I didn't know existed.

Tell me the mistake you made so I don't spend six weeks making it too.

Show me what worked.

Tell me what I can safely ignore.

Give me something I can try tomorrow.

That's not lowering the quality of the education. It's designing the education around the reality of the person consuming it.

I make you a delicious slice of cake, not your dream wedding cake. Custom, sparkles, gold, unicorns.

**EVEN ON YOUR BIRTHDAY**

**We even hope to be the
place you come back
to on your birthday.**

No reservations required. We want you to know the door is always open.

TRANSLATION

The diner is TechUnited. After you complete the program, the community, the events, and the people stay open to you. Just because you've had the burger doesn't mean you shouldn't come back.

HOUSE PHILOSOPHY

Useful

BEFORE

impressive.

Actionable

BEFORE

expansive.

Progress

BEFORE

profundity.

THE DISTANCE

B is yours to reach.

B is what you're doing after you fuel up. After you leave the diner. We have eight weeks. I'm not trying to get you from A to B. You don't need enough fuel to get from A to B in one sitting. You need enough to get to A.1. Then you come back.

I'm trying to give you as many useful opportunities as possible to find:



Maybe we get to A.4 together. Maybe you leave with a roadmap for A.5.

Education alone doesn't create progress, though. That's the thinking behind how we structure mentorship in Uplift around Discover → Act → Roadmap (*this is how we recommend you structure the time you spend with your mentor*).

Where are you actually?

What can you do next?

What have we learned about where you go from there?

Has your waiter ever eaten the food for you?

You still have to do the work.

TRANSLATION

Fuel is what you pick up in a session or with your mentor. A.1 is your next concrete step. Eight weeks gets you a few steps, not the whole trip.



PHASE 2

During these eight weeks, my first job is to make sure you're fed.

Let's say you just moved to the neighborhood. People have recommended this spot a couple of times. Sure, there's the nice restaurant you save for special occasions. This is the place you should be eating at all the time. And let's say it takes about eight weeks to decide what your regular spots are. My first job is to make sure you're fed, and that you have a reason to come back.

The founder who is still trying to get an MVP into someone's hands probably doesn't need a riveting 90-minute conversation about the future of AI, the evolution of venture capital, or the theory of category creation. Interesting? Absolutely. Useful right now? Maybe not.

None of this means I don't value the longer, more expansive conversations. I just think they come next. Our monthly firesides? Bring on the tasting menu. Let's have the expansive conversation.

I want Uplift founders in those rooms. But I want them walking in with more context. Better questions. More vocabulary. A clearer understanding of their business. Maybe an MVP that exists instead of one they're still talking about building.

Uplift doesn't need to contain everything. It needs to prepare you to get more out of everything that comes next.

Uplift is the on-ramp.

THE TABLE

The secret menu item: peers and sounding boards.

This is absolutely not a statistic I've validated, but I'd be willing to bet that underneath all of this, what a majority of founders really want isn't another class anyway.

I'm willing to bet on which table you'd choose, too. That special seat in the back isn't even on the menu. It's the real secret item. They want peers and sounding boards.

Someone to ask, "Have you dealt with this?"

Someone a few steps ahead who can say, "Don't waste your time there."

Someone next to them who says, "I'm dealing with the exact same thing."

That's another reason I don't want long portions of me talking at you to consume the program.

The educational sessions are there to give you tools. The people are there to help you figure out what to do with them.

TRANSLATION

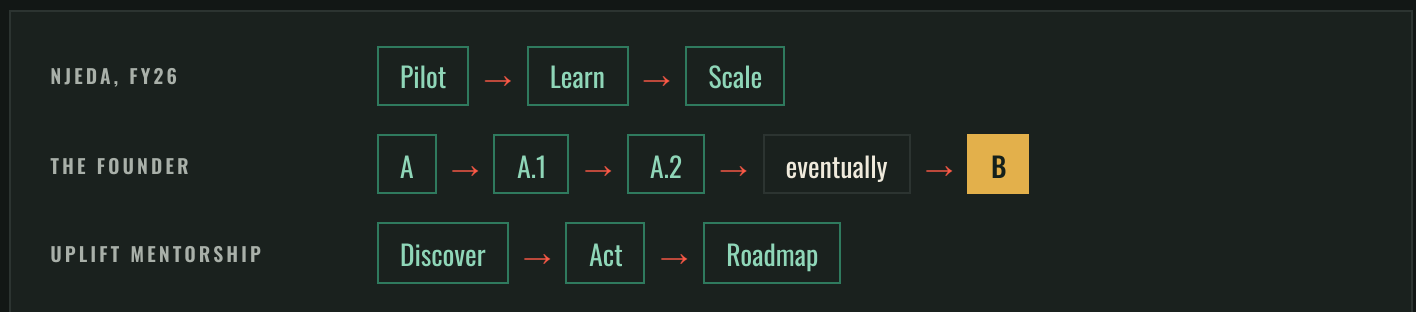
The secret menu item is your cohort and your mentor. The sessions hand you tools. The people help you decide what to do with them.

NJEDA, FY26

Pilot → learn → scale. A → A.1 → A.2 → eventually B.

And I think there's a nice parallel here to the organizations giving us the room to keep experimenting with all of this.

NJEDA has talked about building a “pilot, learn, scale” culture for FY26, alongside its broader mission to increase equitable access to opportunity. Those ideas feel very connected to how we're building Uplift.



SAME SHAPE, THREE SCALES. DISCOVER → ACT → ROADMAP IS HOW WE RECOMMEND YOU STRUCTURE THE TIME YOU SPEND WITH YOUR MENTOR.

Try something. Learn from it. Make the next version better. Keep what works. Change what doesn't. Then grow it.

Everyone here is iterating. The founders, me, and the program itself.

TRANSLATION

We run the program the way we ask founders to run their companies. Try a version, learn from it, adjust, then grow it. NJEDA calls that pilot, learn, scale.

THAT SECOND WORD: ACCESS

Available

≠

Accessible

The more we build this program, the more I think about that second word too. Available and accessible are two very different things.

A resource can be free and still ask for 90 minutes you don't have.

Knowledge can exist and you can still have no idea you need it.

An expert can be in the room and still be talking about something that has nothing to do with the problem in front of you.

Making something available is the easy part. Making it accessible means designing around the person who actually needs to use it.

Equitable doesn't mean giving 70 founders the exact same thing. It means designing enough pathways that people starting from different A's can actually use what's available.

That's what we're trying to get a little better at every cycle.

TRANSLATION

Available is a menu on the wall. Accessible is a server who tells you what's good, in a portion you can finish, at an hour you can actually make.

OPEN FOR BUSINESS

Very grateful to NJEDA and the New Jersey Department of State for giving us the room to keep piloting, learning, and building Uplift alongside the founders it exists to serve.

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